The field of environmental ethics grew out of an urgent sense of encroaching crisis, expressed in both popular and academic writings. In 1962, the book *Silent Spring*, written by US biologist and conservationist Rachel Carson, documented the serious impact of pesticides on the environment, and brought these issues to the forefront of American public debate. Six years later, US ecologist Garrett Hardin's article "The Tragedy of the Commons" outlined the danger of overusing shared resources and allowing the human population to grow unchecked.

Other writers viewed the impending crisis from a more philosophical perspective. Aldo Leopold's "land ethic," outlined in *A Sand County Almanac* (1949), placed human beings on an equal footing with other species in a wider ecosystem. As one part of a larger whole, our ethical concerns should be with the healthy functioning of the entire ecosystem, rather than simply the advancement of human health and happiness.

In his seminal 1966 lecture "The Historical Roots of Our Ecologic Crisis," later published as an article, the US historian Lynn White claimed that the environmental crisis was the fault of Western society's worldview. In particular, he blamed the Christian thinking that promoted anthropocentrism—the idea that humans are superior to all other creatures, leading to the view that nature was created for humanity's use and exploitation.

"A thing is right when it tends to preserve the integrity, stability, and beauty of the biotic community. It is wrong when it tends otherwise."

Aldo Leopold

Ethical dilemmas

Environmental ethics questions the moral imperatives behind sustainability and stewardship by asking if the motivations are grounded in anthropocentrism, or in the protection of the natural world because it